

Targeted and immunotherapy drugs and pregnancy

Targeted and immunotherapy drugs are used to treat different cancers. Most of these cannot be given during pregnancy.

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About targeted therapy and immunotherapy drugs and pregnancy

You cannot take most of these drugs during pregnancy because they are harmful to the baby. Some drugs are still new, so there is not a lot of information about their effects during pregnancy. They are not usually used during a pregnancy.

Your cancer doctor can talk with you about what is known about any drugs or treatments that are offered and what this means for you and your baby.

Breast cancer

If you have [breast cancer](#) and need targeted or immunotherapy drugs such as [trastuzumab](#), [pertuzumab](#) or [pembrolizumab](#) you can have it after the baby is born. During pregnancy, it can reduce the amount of fluid around the baby.

Chronic myeloid leukaemia

[Imatinib](#) (Glivec[®]) is a drug used to treat [chronic myeloid leukaemia \(CML\)](#). It is usually avoided during pregnancy. Drugs similar to imatinib are also usually avoided.

Lymphoma

[Rituximab](#) is a targeted therapy drug used to treat [lymphoma](#). Recent research found the treatment did not seem to cause any problems for the baby. Your specialist may still want to wait until after the baby is born. Your team will discuss treatments options with you.

Advanced melanoma

Targeted therapy drugs used to treat [advanced melanoma](#) are not given during pregnancy. These include:

- [vemurafenib](#) (Zelboraf[®])
- [dabrafenib](#) (Tafinlar[®])
- [trametinib](#) (Mekinist[®]).

Immunotherapy drugs used to treat [advanced melanoma](#) are not given during pregnancy. These include:

- [ipilimumab](#) (Yervoy[®])
- [nivolumab](#) (Opdivo[®])
- [pembrolizumab](#) (Keytruda[®]).

Interferon alpha (IntronA[®], Roferon-A[®]) is an immunotherapy drug that can be given during pregnancy. It can help treat advanced melanoma until after the baby is born. You can then have targeted therapy drugs.

Interferon may also be used during pregnancy to treat [chronic myeloid leukaemia \(CML\)](#).

Getting the right support

If you are pregnant and have cancer, or are worried about treatment and pregnancy:

- Ask to speak to your specialist cancer nurse
- Your care will usually be supported by a multidisciplinary team, including cancer and pregnancy specialists who work together to plan the safest care for you and your baby.

If you need emotional support, practical advice or simply someone to listen, you can contact the Macmillan Support Line on [0808 808 00 00](tel:08088080000), 7 days a week, 8am to 8pm.

Our teams can talk things through with you in confidence.

About our information

This information has been written, revised and edited by Macmillan Cancer Support's Cancer Information Development team. It has been reviewed by expert medical and health professionals and people living with cancer.

References



Below is a sample of the sources used in our pregnancy and cancer information. If you would like more information about the sources we use, please contact us at informationproductionteam@macmillan.org.uk

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Our cancer information meets the [PIF TICK](#) quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about [how we produce our information](#).

The language we use

We want everyone affected by cancer to feel our information is written for them.

We want our information to be as clear as possible. To do this, we try to:

- use plain English
- explain medical words
- use short sentences
- use illustrations to explain text
- structure the information clearly
- make sure important points are clear.

We use gender-inclusive language and talk to our readers as 'you' so that everyone feels included. Where clinically necessary we use the terms 'men' and 'women' or 'male' and 'female'. For example, we do so when talking about parts of the body or mentioning statistics or research about who is affected.

You can read more about how we produce our information [here](#).

How we can help

Macmillan Support Line

The Macmillan Support Line is a free and confidential service for people living with and affected by cancer. If you need to talk, we'll listen.



Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.



Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to call.



Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.



Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.

Get help